

CLASS 10 NOTES

POLITICAL SCIENCE

Political Parties

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POLITICAL PARTIES

Introduction

* Political Party - It is a group of people who come together to contest elections and hold power in the government

* **Components of a political party**

- ↳ The leaders
- ↳ Active Members
- ↳ Followers



Functions of Political Parties

- ↳ Participate in electoral contests, offering choices to voters and competing to gain power through elections.
- ↳ Act as representatives of the people's interests, aggregating diverse opinions and concerns into coherent policies and ideologies.
- ↳ Mobilize citizens, raising awareness about political issues, and encouraging participation in the political process, including voting.
- ↳ Hold the ruling government accountable by monitoring their actions, policies, and decisions, ensuring transparency and checks on power.
- ↳ Form governments by winning elections, either independently or through coalitions, and play a role in the governance process.

- ↳ Play a role in overseeing the implementation of policies and programs initiated by the government, ensuring they align with the party's vision.
- ↳ Encourage public discourse and debates on critical issues, fostering a healthy exchange of ideas within society.

Necessity of Political Parties

- ↳ Political parties represent democracies and the citizens of democracies.
- ↳ Political parties serve as platforms for representing a wide array of opinions, ideologies, and interests present in a society.

* **If there were only independent candidates and no political party :**

- ↳ Difficulty in Forming Government
- ↳ Lack of Coordinated Policy Framework
- ↳ No one would be responsible to look after the country
- ↳ More Focus on Local Issues
- ↳ Enhanced Accountability of Individuals and limited to the constituency only



Different Party Systems

E.M.A

* One - party system

- ↳ Not a democratic option
- ↳ It refers to a political setup where only one political party is legally allowed to hold power, control government positions, and contest elections.
- ↳ Example - China



* Two - party system

- ↳ A two-party system characterizes a political landscape where two major political parties dominate the electoral competition and governance
- ↳ It provides clarity and stability in some aspects, it can also limit diverse representation and the spectrum of political choices
- ↳ Example - US and UK.



* Multi - party system

- ↳ A multi-party system characterizes a political landscape where several political parties compete for power and representation.
- ↳ Coalition government is observed.

- ↳ Example - India.



- * Party system of a country evolves with time and it depends on the nature of society, its social and religious divisions.
- * Currently, more than 750 parties are registered with EC of India.

National Parties

- * The country wide parties are called national parties.
- * There were seven national parties in the country, in 2017.
- * **Criteria for a recognized national party**
 - ↳ 6% of votes in Lok Sabha elections OR 6% of votes in Assembly elections in four states.
 - ↳ Wins at least 4 seats in Lok Sabha elections.
- * **Special facilities offered by EC to registered parties**
 - ↳ They are given a unique party symbol.
 - ↳ They get a status of a political party.
- * **Seven National Parties** ← E.M.A

Bhartiya Janta Party (BJP)

- ↳ Founded in 1980 → Reviving Bhartiya Jan Sangh formed by Shyama Prasad Mukherjee in 1951
- ↳ Ideology
 - ↳ Integral humanism and antyodaya
 - ↳ Integration of J&K, uniform civil code
 - ↳ Indian nationhood
- ↳ 1998 → NDA → in central government after 2014



Indian National Congress (INC)



- ↳ Founded in 1885 and played a very important role in Indian politics after Independence
- ↳ Ideology
 - ↳ Centrist party and support new economic reforms
 - ↳ Build modern secular democratic republic in India
- ↳ Ruling party at center till 1977 to 1989
- ↳ Leader of UPA → At the central Government from 2004 - 2014

All India Trinamool Congress (AITC)



- ↳ Founded on 1 Jan 1998 → By Mamta Banerjee
- ↓
- Recognised National party in 2016
- ↳ In power in West Bengal, since 2011
- ↳ Committed to secularism and federalism
- ↳ 34 seats in 2014 General elections → 4th largest party in Lok Sabha

↓
3.84 % votes

Nationalist Congress Party (NCP)



- ↳ Founded on 1999
- ↳ Member of UPA, since 2004
- ↳ A major party in Maharashtra, Manipur, Meghalaya and Assam

↳ Ideology

- ↳ Promotes democracy, Gandhian, Secularism, equity and social justice
- ↳ Wants the high offices in government be confined to natural born citizens of the country.

Communist Party of India (CPI)



- ↳ Founded on 1925 → got split in CPI and CPI-M in 1964
- ↳ Strong pillar in left front and significant presence in Kerala, West Bengal and Punjab
- ↳ Ideology
 - ↳ Belives in Marxism, Leninism, secularism, and democracy.
 - ↳ Opposed forces of secessionism and communalism

Communist Party of India- Marxist (CPI-M)



- ↳ Founded in 1964, after getting split from CPI
- ↳ Strong presence in West Bengal, Kerala and Tripura.
- ↳ Was in power in West Bengal for almost 34 years continuously.
- ↳ Ideology
 - ↳ Critical of new economic policies that allow free flow of foreign capital and goods
 - ↳ Supported by poor factory workers, farmers, agriculture labourers and intelligentsia.

Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)



- ↳ Founded in 1984 → Under leadership of Kanshi Ram
- ↳ Works on the ideological base of Ambedkar, Sahu Maharaj, Mahatma Phule and Periyar Ramaswami

- ↳ Have strong presence in U.P. and formed coalition government several times
- ↳ Seek to represent and secure power for the bahujan samaj

State Parties

- * All parties other than national parties are called “State Parties” or regional parties.

- * **Importance of State Parties**

- ↳ They make the federal system and democracy more strong.
- ↳ Make the parliament diverse
- ↳ They take care of the local issues and sometimes national parties also take help of state parties to make government.
- ↳ Examples - Shiv Sena, Telugu Desam Party, etc.

- * **Recognition of State Party**

- ↳ 6% of votes in State Legislative Assembly OR win atleast 2 seats

Challenges to Political Parties

E.M.A

- * **Lack of internal democracy**

- ↳ Concentration of power in hands of one or two top leaders
- ↳ A lack of internal democracy can stifle innovation and the ability of a party to adapt to changing societal needs or political landscapes.

* Dynastic Successions

- ↳ Family leaders domination on top positions
- ↳ It might discourage new entrants or ambitious individuals to join party who feel that their opportunities for growth are limited due to established family hierarchies.
- ↳ People with less experience might come to top position which is not good for a party

E.M.A

* Money and muscle power

- ↳ Excessive funds may lead to corruption within parties, fostering a system where policies and decisions are influenced by financial interests rather than the welfare of the populace
- ↳ Parties with substantial financial resources might dominate the political landscape

* Lack of Meaningful Choices

- ↳ No significant difference among the political parties in terms of plans and policies.
- ↳ The fundamental principles remain same.

Reformation of Political Parties

- ↳ Encourage greater internal democracy within parties by promoting transparent processes for candidate selection, policy-making, and decision-taking.
- ↳ Encourage the development of innovative policies and clear, transparent communication about these policies to engage voters.

- ↳ Implement measures to reduce the influence of money in politics.
- ↳ Regular performance evaluations, transparency reports, and public forums can help maintain accountability to constituents.

Top 7 previous year questions

Short questions

1. What is meant by Regional political party? State the condition required to be recognised as a regional political party.

Regional political party exists, operates and functions at the regional level. It gives prominence to regional issues, specific problems of the region and it has influence only on the people of that region. It lays more stress on regional culture identity, which it wants to preserve and promote.

Conditions required to be recognised as a Regional political party are

- (i) It should have polled at least 6% valid votes in an election to the Legislative Assembly.
- (ii) It has reached in at least three states in last general election.
- (iii) It had won at least 2 seats in Legislative elections.

2. What is meant by 'defection' in democracy? Explain.

Defection in democracy is a political phenomena. It means moving of a person from one party to another party for some personal benefit. It happens when a legislature, after having been elected from a particular party leaves it and joins in other party.

Anti-Defection Law was formulated to prevent elected MLA's and MP's from changing parties. Now the law states that if any MLA or MP changes parties, he or she will lose seat in the legislature. The new law has brought percentage of defection down and has made dissent even more difficult.

3. Describe any three broad guidelines for devising ways and means for political reforms in India.

The three broad guidelines for devising ways and means for political reforms in India are

- (i) A law should be made to regulate the internal affairs of political parties. Political parties should maintain a register of its members, to hold open elections, to follow its own Constitution, etc.
- (ii) Political parties can be monitored by ordinary citizens, pressure groups, media, etc. Pressure on political parties can be done through petitions, publicity and agitation.
- (ii) The quality of democracy depends on the degree of public participation. It is difficult to reform politics if ordinary citizens do not directly participate in politics and simply criticise it from outside.

4. Explain merits and demerits of multi-party system.

Merits of the multi-party system are

- (i) Multi-party system allows a variety of interests and opinions to enjoy political representation.
- (ii) In this system, people have an opportunity to choose between several candidates.

Demerits of the multi-party system are

- (i) This system often appears very messy.
- (ii) This system sometimes leads to political instability

5. What is the role of the opposition party in a democracy?

The opposition party plays a very important role in a democracy as

- (i) It acts as pressure group.
- (ii) It mobilises the government.
- (iii) It keeps a check on the working of the ruling party.
- (iv) It puts different views in the Parliament and criticize the government for its failures or wrong policies.

Long questions

6. "Lack of internal democracy is a challenge to efficient functioning of Indian political parties." Justify the statement.

Lack of internal democracy is a challenge to the efficient functioning of political parties. The following points justify the statements

- (i) All over the world, there is a tendency in political parties towards the concentration of power in one or few leaders at the top.
- (ii) Parties do not keep membership registers, do not hold organisational meetings and do not conduct internal elections regularly.
- (iii) Ordinary members of the party do not get sufficient information on what happens inside the party. They do not have the means or the connection needed to influence the decisions. As a result, the leaders assume greater power to make decision in the name of the party.
- (iv) Since one or few leaders exercise the power in the party, those who disagree with the leadership find it difficult to continue in the party.

7. Why has India adopted a multi-party system?

India adopted multi-party system for the following reasons

- (i) India being a vast and diverse country, the multi-party system was needed to accommodate the vast population.
- (ii) The social and geographical diversity of India could not be represented by two or three parties.
- (iii) The multi-party system in India evolved over a long time, depending on the nature of society, social, regional division, its history of politics and its system of elections.
- (iv) Multi-party system ensures a healthy competition between different parties and prevents dictatorship of a single party. Indian Constitution declares India as a democratic country. Multi-party system fulfils this criteria and provides chance for proper growth of the nation.

EXPHUB 9 & 10